

Seminar in Memory and Forgetting

Gabriel I. Cook

This course is an in-depth analysis of human learning and memory. Everyday memory is characterized both by exceptional powers and by peculiar limitations. For example, we may recall complex details of events experienced either outside of awareness or long ago during childhood, yet also struggle to remember simple details of memories formulated just seconds before interruptions. Everyday we create mental records of our personal experiences and our plans for the future and we use those records in order to reminisce, survive, create, and interact in socially acceptable ways. This seminar explores the functionality of human memory by critically evaluating both its powers and limitations in creating those mental records in an attempt to understand what they reveal about its nature. Important findings and conceptual frameworks in both contemporary memory theory, as well as classical theories that have remained influential to this day are discussed. This course focuses primarily on how memory experiences in real world contexts. Among the topics considered are the encoding and retrieval of memories, emotional influences on memory, amnesia and other capacity limitations, the development and aging of memory in the individual, autobiographical memory and self, memory disorders and distortions, and techniques for improving learning and memory. Course topics are covered in a seminar and workshop format. Students read and lead discussions on the assigned articles and other readings, present and articulate the importance of data, design experiments, and often work either individually or as members of small groups on related topics.

Anticipated Topics:

Bartlett's Constructive View of Remembering
Working Memory
Encoding and Retrieval
Implicit and Explicit Memory
Memory Distortions and Limitations
Mnemonics, Cues, and Memory Strategies
The Development of Personal Memory
Personal and Public Memories: Flashbulbs and Memorials
Collective Memory and other Social Influences
Eyewitness Testimony
Source Memory: Distinguishing Reality from Imagination
The Anatomy and Neuropsychology of Memory

Required texts and materials:

Hunt, R. R., & Ellis, H. C. (2004). *Fundamentals of cognitive psychology*, 7th edition. New York: McGraw-Hill.

Neath, I., & Surprenant, A. M. (2003). *Human Memory, Second Edition*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

Potential Supplemental Readings:

Bartlett, F. C. (1932). *Remembering: A study in experimental and social psychology*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Brown, A. S. (1991) A review of the tip-of-the-tongue experience. *Psychological Bulletin*, 109, 204-223.

Ebbinghaus, H. (1885) *Memory: A contribution to experimental psychology*.

Haber, R. N. & Haber, L. (2000). Experiencing, remembering and reporting events. *Psychology, Public Policy & Law*, 6, 1057-1097.

Howe, M. L. & Courage, M. L. (1993). On resolving the enigma of infantile amnesia. *Psychological Bulletin*, 113, 305-326.

Johnston, E. B. (2001). The repeated reproduction of remembering. *History of Psychology*, 4, 341-366.

Pillemer, D. B. (1998). *Momentous events, vivid memories*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press. (Chapter 4: Image, Narrative and the Development of Self.)

Schacter, D. S. (1996). *Searching for memory*. New York: Basic Books.

Schacter, D. L. (2001). *The seven sins of memory*. New York: Houghton Mifflin.

Wells, G. et al (2000). From the lab to the police station: A successful application of eyewitness research. *American Psychologist*, 55, 581-598.

Weldon, M.S. & Bellinger, K.D. (1997). Collective Memory: Collaborative and Individual Processes in Remembering. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition*, 23, 1160-1175.

Wheeler, M., Stuss, D. & Tulving, E. (1997). Toward a theory of episodic memory: The frontal lobes and autonoetic consciousness. *Psychological Bulletin*, 121, 331-354.